

Model

1 Model

1.1 Environment

Consider a metropolitan area consisting of a finite set of locations $S = \{1, 2, \dots, n\}$. These locations are partitioned into municipalities $g \in G$:

$$S = \bigcup_{g \in G} S^g, \quad S^g \cap S^{g'} = \emptyset \quad \text{for } g \neq g'.$$

Each location $i \in S$ is endowed with a fixed supply of land $\bar{H}_i$, allocated between residential and commercial use by local zoning:

$$\bar{H}_i^R + \bar{H}_i^F = \bar{H}_i,$$

where $\bar{H}_i^R$ is residential floor space capacity and $\bar{H}_i^F$ is commercial floor space capacity. Both are chosen by the municipal government and assumed to be fully utilized in equilibrium.

Locations are connected by a transportation network. The generalized commuting cost from residence i to workplace j is

$$\tau_{ij} = \tau_{ij}(I_{ij}, n_{ij}),$$

where I_{ij} is transportation investment on link (i, j) and n_{ij} is the equilibrium commuter flow on that link. Investment reduces commuting costs and congestion raises them:

$$\frac{\partial \tau_{ij}}{\partial I_{ij}} \leq 0, \quad \frac{\partial \tau_{ij}}{\partial n_{ij}} \geq 0.$$

Following Fajgelbaum and Schaal, 2020, I parametrize the commuting cost as

$$\tau_{ij} = \delta_{ij}^\tau \frac{n_{ij}^\rho}{I_{ij}^\gamma},$$

where $\delta_{ij}^\tau > 0$ captures geographic features of link (i, j) and $\rho, \gamma > 0$.

There are three types of agents: households, competitive firms, and governments. Households choose residence and workplace locations. Firms produce a freely tradable good using labor and commercial floor space. Government decisions operate at two levels: municipal governments choose local zoning, and a metropolitan transportation authority chooses investment across all links. In the decentralized equilibrium, municipalities and the transportation authority choose policies simultaneously, each treating the other's decisions as given.

1.2 Households

A household chooses a residence location i and a workplace j to maximize utility. Preferences over the composite good Q_{ij} and residential floor space h_{ij}^R are Cobb-Douglas:

$$u_{ij}(\omega) = \frac{B_i}{\tau_{ij}} \left(\frac{Q_{ij}}{\alpha} \right)^\alpha \left(\frac{h_{ij}^R}{1-\alpha} \right)^{1-\alpha} v_{ij}(\omega),$$

where $B_i > 0$ is a residential amenity at location i , $\alpha \in (0, 1)$ is the expenditure share on the composite good, and $v_{ij}(\omega)$ is an idiosyncratic preference shock drawn independently for each (i, j) pair.

The household's budget constraint is

$$Q_{ij} + q_i^R h_{ij}^R \leq w_j - \phi(N_i, L_i),$$

where q_i^R is the residential rent at location i , w_j is the wage at workplace j , and $\phi(N_i, L_i)$ is a monetary disutility from residing at i . The disutility captures two sources of local negative externalities: residential congestion from neighbors and the presence of workers near the residential location:

$$\frac{\partial \phi}{\partial N_i} > 0, \quad \frac{\partial \phi}{\partial L_i} > 0,$$

where N_i denotes residential population and L_i denotes employment at location i (defined below).

Define effective income as $Y_{ij} \equiv w_j - \phi(N_i, L_i)$. Optimal demands are $Q_{ij}^* = \alpha Y_{ij}$ and $h_{ij}^{R*} = (1 - \alpha) Y_{ij} / q_i^R$. Substituting into the utility function yields the deterministic component of indirect utility:

$$\tilde{V}_{ij} = \frac{B_i Y_{ij}}{\tau_{ij} (q_i^R)^{1-\alpha}}.$$

The idiosyncratic shock $v_{ij}(\omega)$ is drawn from a Fréchet distribution with $\Pr(v_{ij} \leq z) = \exp(-T_i E_j z^{-\epsilon})$, where $T_i > 0$ and $E_j > 0$ are location-specific scale parameters and $\epsilon > 1$ governs the dispersion of idiosyncratic tastes. By the Fréchet aggregation property, the probability that a household chooses residence i and workplace j is

$$\pi_{ij} = \frac{T_i E_j \tilde{V}_{ij}^\epsilon}{\Phi}, \quad \Phi \equiv \sum_{i'} \Phi_{i'}, \quad \Phi_i \equiv \sum_j T_i E_j \tilde{V}_{ij}^\epsilon, \quad (1)$$

and expected utility is

$$U = \Gamma(1 - \frac{1}{\epsilon}) \Phi^{1/\epsilon}. \quad (2)$$

Let N denote total metropolitan population, fixed in a closed economy. Equilibrium residential population at each location is

$$N_i = N \sum_j \pi_{ij}.$$

Residential floor space market clearing at location i pins down the equilibrium rent:

$$q_i^R = \frac{(1 - \alpha) \sum_j N \pi_{ij} Y_{ij}}{\bar{H}_i^R}. \quad (3)$$

1.3 Firms

At each location j , competitive firms produce a freely tradable good using labor L_j and commercial floor space H_j^F :

$$Y_j = A_j L_j^\gamma (H_j^F)^{1-\gamma},$$

where $A_j > 0$ is location-specific productivity and $\gamma \in (0, 1)$. Taking wages w_j and commercial rents q_j^F as given, profit maximization yields:

$$w_j = \gamma A_j \left(\frac{H_j^F}{L_j} \right)^{1-\gamma}, \quad q_j^F = (1-\gamma) A_j \left(\frac{L_j}{H_j^F} \right)^\gamma.$$

Commercial floor space is constrained by zoning: $H_j^F = \bar{H}_j^F$. Labor market clearing at j gives

$$L_j = N \sum_i \pi_{ij},$$

determined by household location choices. The disutility $\phi(N_i, L_i)$ uses L_i to denote employment at location i acting as a workplace, which is this same quantity evaluated at $j = i$.

1.4 Municipal Zoning

Each municipality $g \in G$ chooses the land-use allocation $\{\bar{H}_i^R, \bar{H}_i^F\}_{i \in S^g}$ to maximize the total welfare of its residents. In line with the political economy of local land use (Mast, 2024; Rollet and Weiwu, 2025), the municipal government acts as a representative of its residents, who face a tradeoff between lower housing costs — which favor denser zoning — and lower congestion and fewer workers near their homes — which favor restrictive zoning. Formally, municipality g solves

$$\max_{\{\bar{H}_i^R\}_{i \in S^g}} W^g = \sum_{i \in S^g} N_i \bar{U}_i,$$

where N_i is the equilibrium population at location i and $\bar{U}_i = \Gamma(1 - \frac{1}{\epsilon}) \Phi_i^{1/\epsilon}$ is the expected utility of a representative resident at location i , subject to $\bar{H}_i^R + \bar{H}_i^F = \bar{H}_i$ for each $i \in S^g$, taking other municipalities' allocations $\{\bar{H}_{i'}^R, \bar{H}_{i'}^F\}_{i' \notin S^g}$ and transportation investment $\{I_{jk}\}$ as given.

Substituting $\bar{H}_i^F = \bar{H}_i - \bar{H}_i^R$ and differentiating $\sum_{i \in S^g} N_i \bar{U}_i$ with respect to $\bar{H}_i^R$, the interior first-order condition at location $i \in S^g$ is

$$\underbrace{\bar{U}_i \frac{\partial N_i}{\partial \bar{H}_i^R}}_{\geq 0 \text{ (in-movers)}} + N_i \underbrace{\frac{\partial \bar{U}_i}{\partial q_i^R} \frac{\partial q_i^R}{\partial \bar{H}_i^R}}_{\geq 0 \text{ (rent benefit)}} + N_i \underbrace{\frac{\partial \bar{U}_i}{\partial \phi} \frac{\partial \phi}{\partial N_i} \frac{\partial N_i}{\partial \bar{H}_i^R}}_{\leq 0 \text{ (congestion cost)}} + N_i \underbrace{\left(-\frac{\partial \bar{U}_i}{\partial \phi} \frac{\partial \phi}{\partial L_i} \frac{\partial L_i}{\partial \bar{H}_i^F} \right)}_{\geq 0 \text{ (less worker influx)}} = 0. \quad (4)$$

The first term is positive: looser zoning lowers rents, attracting additional residents from the rest of the metro area; each in-mover contributes $\bar{U}_i$ to the municipality's objective. The second term is positive: lower rents raise effective income for all N_i existing residents. The third term is negative: in-movers raise N_i , worsening congestion for all current residents through ϕ . The fourth term is positive: shifting land from commercial to residential reduces employment L_i and the associated worker congestion. The municipality sets $\bar{H}_i^R$ where the benefit of attracting residents and lowering rents is offset by the congestion they impose.

1.5 Transportation Authority

The metropolitan transportation authority chooses investment $\{I_{jk}\}_{j,k \in S}$ to maximize aggregate household welfare, taking the full zoning vector $\{\bar{H}_i^R, \bar{H}_i^F\}$ as given:

$$\max_{\{I_{jk}\}} N \cdot \Gamma\left(1 - \frac{1}{\epsilon}\right) \Phi^{1/\epsilon}$$

subject to the budget constraint

$$\sum_{j,k} \delta_{jk} I_{jk} \leq K, \quad I_{jk} \geq 0,$$

where δ_{jk} is the per-unit cost of investment on link (j, k) and K is the total infrastructure budget.

Let $\mu \geq 0$ be the Lagrange multiplier on the budget constraint. The interior first-order condition for link (j, k) is

$$\frac{N}{\epsilon} \Gamma\left(1 - \frac{1}{\epsilon}\right) \Phi^{1/\epsilon-1} \frac{\partial \Phi}{\partial I_{jk}} = \mu \delta_{jk}. \quad (5)$$

The left-hand side is the marginal social benefit of investment on link (j, k) : lower commuting costs raise $\tilde{V}_{ij}$ for all commuters on that link, increasing Φ and hence aggregate welfare. The authority equates the marginal benefit per dollar of investment across all active links.

1.6 Equilibrium

Definition 1 (Decentralized Equilibrium). A decentralized equilibrium is a profile

$$\left(\{\bar{H}_i^{R*}, \bar{H}_i^{F*}\}_{i \in S}, \{I_{jk}^*\}, \{q_i^{R*}, q_i^{F*}, w_j^*\}_{i,j \in S} \right)$$

such that:

1. **Household optimality.** Commuting flows $\{N\pi_{ij}^*\}$ are given by the Fréchet probability formula at prices (q_i^{R*}, w_j^*) and investment I^* .
2. **Firm optimality.** Wages w_j^* and commercial rents q_j^{F*} satisfy the firm first-order conditions at $H_j^F = \bar{H}_j^{F*}$ and $L_j^* = N \sum_i \pi_{ij}^*$.
3. **Market clearing.** Residential floor space, commercial floor space, and labor markets clear at each location.
4. **Municipal Nash equilibrium.** Each municipality g maximizes its objective given $\{\bar{H}_{i'}^{R*}, \bar{H}_{i'}^{F*}\}_{i' \notin S^g}$ and I^* ; no municipality has a profitable deviation.
5. **Transportation authority optimality.** $\{I_{jk}^*\}$ maximizes aggregate welfare given $\{\bar{H}_i^{R*}, \bar{H}_i^{F*}\}$ subject to the budget constraint.

Conditions (iv) and (v) jointly constitute the simultaneous Nash equilibrium between municipalities and the transportation authority: each set of agents takes the other's choices as given and best-responds.

1.7 Social Planner

A social planner jointly chooses zoning allocations $\{\bar{H}_i^R, \bar{H}_i^F\}$ and transportation investment $\{I_{jk}\}$ to maximize aggregate household welfare:

$$\max_{\{\bar{H}_i^R, \bar{H}_i^F\}, \{I_{jk}\}} N \cdot \Gamma\left(1 - \frac{1}{\epsilon}\right) \Phi^{1/\epsilon}$$

subject to the budget constraint $\sum_{j,k} \delta_{jk} I_{jk} \leq K$, land constraints $\bar{H}_i^R + \bar{H}_i^F = \bar{H}_i$ for all i , and market clearing.

Comparing the planner’s first-order condition for zoning with the municipal condition in (4) reveals two positive terms that municipalities systematically ignore. First, because each municipality g maximizes welfare only over $i \in S^g$, it ignores the welfare of residents in neighboring municipalities who gain from lower rents and more accessible housing when g rezones — even though those residents move voluntarily and are made better off. Second, municipalities do not account for the transit-zoning complementarity: denser residential and commercial development near transit-accessible locations raises ridership and the marginal return to transit investment, generating a positive externality on the transportation authority’s problem. Road investment is comparatively less sensitive to local density, so this externality operates asymmetrically across infrastructure types.

Both omitted terms are positive, implying that decentralized municipalities choose zoning that is too restrictive on both margins relative to the social optimum:

$$\bar{H}_i^{R,SP} \geq \bar{H}_i^{R,DE}, \quad \bar{H}_i^{F,SP} \geq \bar{H}_i^{F,DE} \quad \text{for all } i \in S.$$

The decentralized equilibrium therefore features underinvestment in transit — not because the transportation authority errs given the zoning it observes, but because the zoning it faces is itself distorted by fragmented local governance.

References

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- [2] Evan Mast. “Warding off Development: Local Control, Housing Supply, and NIM-BYs”. en. In: *The Review of Economics and Statistics* 106 (3 May 14, 2024), pp. 671–680.
- [3] Vincent Rollet and Laura Weiwu. *Measuring Winners and Losers from Increasing Housing Supply*. en. Research rep. 2025.